

Engine change behind enemy lines

"Hurricane," a Sherman serving with Company H, 66th Armored Regiment of the 2nd Armored Division, came ashore at Utah Beach on June 9, 1944. By August 16, it was in need of a new engine and here, behind the lines at Teilleul in Normandy, France, a new Continental R-975-C4 engine was readied to be dropped into the hull by a wrecker.

Tanks—because of the stresses and strains they undergo—wear out components quickly. Climate and terrain have an obvious effect: dust in hot climates can enter the engine and act as a grinding paste along with sand and gravel, while in cold climates metal can become brittle, and fluids within the tank can freeze, causing damage. Inexperienced or undertrained

crews could also damage vehicles, and the nature of battle meant that maintenance could not always be properly carried out, leading to breakdowns and component failures.

When the British Army first received US tanks in 1941, there was general agreement that maintenance of US vehicles was much easier than contemporary British designs. For a tank crew in the field, easier maintenance meant less time spent carrying it out, and that meant the greater possibility of a good night's sleep.

M4 Sherman "Hurricane" has its engine changed in Normandy, France, in 1944. The Sherman's manual dedicated 16 pages to engine changes.

